

Gender Binary

doc-gender-binary
Anthropology · Created Order · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

God created humanity male and female as a fixed binary rooted in creation; biological sex and gender identity are coherent and not subject to self-determined redefinition.

In plain language

From the first chapter the Bible names the two sexes of humanity with one fixed word pair. Genesis 1:27 says God created the human (adam) 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah), and Genesis 5:2 repeats the same pair as the standing name of the species. The honest question is whether this pair is a closed binary or an open figure like 'heaven and earth' that names a whole and includes everything in between. The words answer it. The same pair 'male' (zakar, H2145) and 'female' (neqevah, H5347) runs through the law, and there it always sorts a group into exactly two bins with nothing left over. The clearest case is the vow law of Leviticus 27, which prices every dedicated person by age and then as either male or female, two prices and no third. The flood account even pairs the two terms with the number two. So the pair does not gesture at a spectrum, it partitions a whole into two. Genesis 2 narrates the same thing as story: God builds the 'woman' (ishshah) from the side of the 'man' (ish), and the man names her on the basis of where she came from, tying the word pair to the body pair, and the two become 'one flesh' (basar echad) in marriage. When Jesus is asked about marriage in Matthew 19:4 and Mark 10:6 he quotes Genesis 1:27 word for word in Greek, 'male' (arsen, G730) and 'female' (thely, G2338), and locates the pair from the beginning of creation. Paul uses the same Greek pair in Romans 1:26-27 with the phrase 'natural use' (phusike chresis). Galatians 3:28 reuses the very words but about standing in Christ, and even there it switches to the 'and' (kai) of the creation formula to signal it is echoing Genesis, not erasing the categories. No passage adds a third term beside male and female. The lexical pattern supports the proposition.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	944
H0376	איש	ish	man	2,188
H0802	אשה	ishshah	woman	781
H1129	בנה	banah	to build	
H1254	ברא	bara	to create	46
H1320	בשר	basar	flesh	250
H2145	זכר	zakar	male	80
H5347	נקבה	neqevah	female	22

H6754	תְּצַלֵּם	tselem	image	16
H6763	צֶלַע	tsela	side	
G0730	ἀρσεν	arsen	male	9
G0746	ἀρχή	archē	beginning	
G2135	εὐνοῦχος	eunouchos	eunuch	8
G2338	θηλυς	thelys	female	5
G5446	φυσικός	phusikos	natural	3
G5540	χρησις	chresis	use	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

A single fixed two-term word pair describes humanity at creation across the Law of Moses (Torah) and the Gospels. Genesis 1:27 makes 'male' (zakar, H2145) and 'female' (neqevah, H5347) the terminal specification of the verb 'to create' (bara, H1254A) with God as the subject, repeated at Genesis 5:2. The whole-canon distribution settles the merism question (a merism is a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) against an open reading: in the 15 verses where the pair stands together it always sorts a set exhaustively into exactly two bins, and the vow valuations of Leviticus 27:3-7 price every person as either 'the male' (ha-zakar) or 'for the female' (la-neqevah) with no third bracket, so the pair partitions a whole rather than gesturing at a spectrum. Jesus quotes the pair verbatim in Matthew 19:4 and Mark 10:6 as 'male and female he made them' (arsen kai thely epoiesen autous), anchored 'from the beginning' (ap arches), and Paul reuses 'male' (arsen) and 'female' (thely) with 'natural use' (phusike chresis) in Romans 1:26-27. No canonical text places a third anthropological term beside 'male' (zakar) and 'female' (neqevah) or 'male' (arsen) and 'female' (thely).

Scripture

Gen.1.27 · **for** · genre: narrative · figures: merism

Key terms. H2145 זָכָר, H5347 נִקְבָּה, H1254A בָּרָא, H6754 תְּצַלֵּם

Reasoning. Triple use of the Hebrew narrative past form (wayyiqtol) and the completed-action form (qatal) of 'to create' (bara) with God as subject and 'the human' (ha-adam) as object, terminated by the bipartite specification 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah). The verse text reads 'male and female he created them' (zakar uneqevah bara otam). Read with the canon-wide usage of this exact pair, the two terms function as a closed two-term specification of the created human, not as a sample drawn from a larger set.

Gen.5.2 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2145 זָכָר, H5347 נִקְבָּה, H1254A בָּרָא

Reasoning. Re-quotation of the creation pair at the head of the family record (toledot) of Adam: 'male and female he created them' (zakar uneqevah beraam), and he called their name 'human' (adam). The same two-term pair names the species and is the standing description, reinforcing the closed binary outside the immediate creation account.

Gen.7.9 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2145 זָכָר, H5347 נִקְבָּה

Reasoning. 'Two by two' (shenayim shenayim) they came to the ark, 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah). The narrative explicitly equates the 'male' (zakar) and 'female' (neqevah) pair with the numeral two. Across the flood texts (Genesis 6:19, 7:3, 7:9, 7:16) the pair stands for the whole breeding population of each kind with no remaining category, which is the lexical signature of an exhaustive partition rather than an open merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole).

Lev.27.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5347 נִקְבָּה, H2145 זָכָר

Reasoning. The vow-valuation law sorts every dedicated person by age and then by the conditional pair (an 'if-then' clause) 'if male' (im zakar), then 'and if female' (veim neqevah). Leviticus 27:3-7 sets two and only two prices in each age bracket, one for 'the male' (ha-zakar) and one for 'for the female' (la-neqevah), with no third valuation. This 'if, and if' (im, veim) conditional exhaustively classifies every individual into one of two and leaves no remainder, which is decisive that the pair is an exhaustive binary, not a two-term stand-in for a continuum.

Gen.2.22 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0802 אִשָּׁה, H6763 צִלַּע, H1129 בְּנָה

Reasoning. God 'builds' (banah) the 'woman' (ishshah) from the 'side' (tsela) of the 'human' (adam), establishing the female counterpart by direct creative act. The origin of the second term is narrated as a divine making, not a self-assignment.

Gen.2.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0376 אִישׁ, H0802 אִשָּׁה, H1320 בִּשְׂרָ

Reasoning. The 'human' (adam) names the counterpart 'woman' (ishshah) on the morphological basis of 'man' (ish): this one shall be called 'woman' (ishshah), for from 'man' (ish) she was taken. The naming locks the linguistic pair to the bodily pair 'bone' (etsem) and 'flesh' (basar). The naming follows from the bodily derivation rather than from preference.

Gen.2.24 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0376 אִישׁ, H0802 אִשָּׁה, H1320 בִּשְׂרָ, H0259 אֶחָד

Reasoning. An origin-explaining 'therefore' (al-ken) clause grounds marriage in the prior creation pair. A 'man' (ish) leaves and cleaves to his 'woman' (ishshah) and the two become 'one flesh' (basar echad). The one-flesh formula presupposes and requires the two-term male-and-female pair.

Matt.19.4 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0730 ἄρσεν, G2338 θῆλυ, G0746 ἀρχή

Reasoning. Jesus cites Genesis 1:27 verbatim: 'the one who created from the beginning made them male and female' (ho ktisas ap arches arsen kai thely epoiesen autous). The completed-past form 'he made' (aorist, a completed past action: epoiesen) with 'from the beginning' (ap arches) locates the binary at creation as a completed divine act. Jesus then quotes Genesis 2:24 in verse 5, binding the pair to marriage and one-flesh union.

Mark.10.6 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0730 ἄρσεν, G2338 θῆλυ, G0746 ἀρχή

Reasoning. Parallel citation of Genesis 1:27: 'but from the beginning of creation he made them male and female' (apo de arches ktiseos arsen kai thely epoiesen autous). The added 'of creation' (genitive, a noun in the 'of-X' form: ktiseos) makes explicit that the male-and-female pair is a created order, located at the start of creation rather than a later cultural development.

Rom.1.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2338 θήλειαι, G5446 φυσικός, G5540 χρήσις

Reasoning. Paul pairs 'the females' (hai theleiai) with 'natural use' (phusiken chresin) and its opposite 'against nature' (para phusin). The verse presupposes that 'nature' (phusis) here carries a normative content given with the two-term pattern, traceable to the same Genesis 1:27 vocabulary used in the Gospels.

Rom.1.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0730 ἄρσενες, G2338 θηλείας, G5540 χρήσις

Reasoning. 'The males' (hoi arsenes) leaving 'the natural use of the female' (ten phusiken chresin tes theleias). The verse uses 'male' (arsen) three times and 'female' (thely) once, the same lexical pair as Genesis 1:27 in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, abbreviated LXX), Matthew 19:4, and Mark 10:6, applied to natural sexual use.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.19.4	Gen.1.27	tsk	1
Mark.10.6	Gen.1.27	tsk	1
Mark.10.6	Gen.1.1	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Gen.2.21	tsk	1
Matt.19.5	Gen.2.21	tsk	1
Gen.2.22	Gen.2.19	tsk	1
Gen.2.24	Mal.2.14	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Isa.43.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gal.3.28 · addressed

'There is no male and female' (ouk eni arsen kai thely) reuses the exact Genesis 1:27 pair from the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX). The Greek is decisive: the first two contrasts in the verse use 'nor' (oude), as in 'neither Jew nor Greek' (Ioudaios oude Hellen) and 'slave nor free' (doulos oude eleutheros), but the third switches to 'and' (kai), as in 'male and female' (arsen kai thely), the connective of the creation formula, marking it as a deliberate echo of Genesis 1:27 rather than a denial of the categories themselves. The stated scope is 'in Christ Jesus' (en Christo Iesou), saving standing before God (soteriological standing), not the abolition of created sex. The text complicates only a reading that conflates standing in Christ with anthropological category.

Matt.19.12 · addressed

Jesus names three 'eunuch' (eunouchos, G2135) groups: born so, made so by men, and self-made for the kingdom. The whole-canon use of 'eunuch' (eunouchos), found only in Matthew 19:12 and the Ethiopian official of Acts 8, describes a male who does not procreate, not a non-male or a third sex. The framing pair from verse 4, 'male' (arsen) and 'female' (thely), is unaffected. A 'eunuch' (eunouchos) is lexically a class of male, so the binary holds.

Jer.31.22 · addressed

'Female' (neqevah) occurs here without 'male' (zakar) in the obscure clause 'a female shall encompass a man' (neqevah tesovev gaver). This is the one poetic and prophetic use of 'female' (neqevah) outside the creation and legal pattern, and its sense is debated at the verse level. It does not introduce a third term and does not redefine 'female' (neqevah). It simply uses the female term in a figure whose referent is unclear. It cannot overturn the dense, repeated, exhaustive-sort usage that fixes the pair elsewhere.

Concordance traversed

H2145, H5347, G0730, G2338, H1254A, H6754, H0376, H0802, H1320, H0259, G5446, G5540, G2135

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The anchor verses lie outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so no CBGM (coherence-based genealogical method) apparatus applies. The 'male and female' (arsen kai thely) pair in Matthew 19:4, Mark 10:6, Romans 1:26-27, and Galatians 3:28 is textually stable in the verse text examined, and the Hebrew 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah) in Genesis 1:27 and Genesis 5:2 is uncontested. The marked sigla (editorial symbols flagging variants) in the source text touch surrounding words, not the lexical pair, so the verdict does not turn on any variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation_order, intra-canonical_citation

analogia scripturae invoked

exhaustive-binary reading: affirms · Across the canon the pair 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah), and its Greek counterpart 'male and female' (arsen kai thely), sorts every member of a set into exactly two mutually exclusive bins. Leviticus 27:3-7 prices each vowed person as either male or female with no third valuation, the ark texts pair the two terms with the numeral two, and no verse adds a third anthropological term. On this reading Genesis 1:27 states the binary as a closed creational specification, and Jesus and Paul cite it as such.

open-merism reading: disputed-toward-affirm · A merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) is a two-term pair naming a whole, as in 'heaven and earth' meaning everything in between included. On this reading Genesis 1:27, taken as narrative, reports the two principal cases at creation and the verse itself supplies no explicit quantifier such as 'only' or 'no other', so it could be read as descriptive of the two normal poles rather than as legislating exhaustive scope. This is the strongest minority reading. The lexical answer to it is that a merism includes the middle in the whole, whereas the legal usage of this same pair partitions individuals into two priced bins with a remainder of none, so the canon distribution closes the gap the bare narrative leaves open.

creation_order: affirms · Jesus anchors the pair 'from the beginning' (ap arches) and 'from the beginning of creation' (apo arches ktiseos), and Paul appeals to 'nature' (phusis), so the binary is presented as given with creation rather than as a later convention. The completed-past form 'he made' (aorist, a completed past action: epoiesen) frames it as a completed divine act.

Jesus reads Genesis 1:27 and Genesis 2:24 as a single creational ordinance applied to marriage in Matthew 19 and Mark 10. Paul's appeal to 'natural use' (phusike chresis) in Romans 1 presupposes the same anchor. The honest lexical tension is whether Genesis 1:27 alone is prescriptive or merely descriptive, and the canon-wide exhaustive-sort usage of the same word pair is what resolves it toward prescriptive.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the canonical vocabulary describe humanity-as-created with a closed two-term pair (male and female), and does any canonical text add a third anthropological term beside it?

The stem couples a defensible lexical claim (a creational male-and-female pair) with contemporary framing tokens (fixed binary, gender identity, self-determined redefinition) that are not in the biblical vocabulary. The verdict is derived only from the words: the recurring 'male and female' (zakar uneqevah) and 'male and female' (arsen kai thely) pair and its exhaustive-sort usage. The phrases about identity and redefinition are answered only to the extent the text speaks, namely that the second term arises by divine making (Genesis 2:22) and naming-from-derivation (Genesis 2:23), not by self-assignment. The contemporary clause is neutralized so the verdict is not smuggled by the stem.

Citations

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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0730
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